

Restoring a Little One

The Minor of Forgiveness Becomes Major in Prayer

For this month of April, a month of fasting and prayer, we have gone back to the basics. We began by majoring on minors, because many times the minors are the majors.

The major is Mark 11:23-24:

Whosoever shall say unto this mountain, Be thou removed, and be thou cast into the sea; and shall not doubt in his heart... he shall have whatsoever he saith.

What things soever ye desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive them, and ye shall have them.

But Mark 11:25 is the minor:

And when ye stand praying, forgive, if ye have ought against any...

When you stand praying, if you have ought, forgive, so your heavenly Father can forgive and answer your prayer. So we studied forgiveness because it is absolutely necessary in prayer. We found out what greatness is in the kingdom, and now we will take it one step further.

Father, we want to learn. We are hungry. These minors, which usually turn out to be majors, are often the little foxes that spoil the vines. We want to live a life in God infused by Your power. We want to be devastating in prayer and effective. We thank You for miracles, but corporately we ask You to teach us Your Word. Hearing it and understanding it not only sets us free, but supplies all the power we need to walk in it. Amen.

Greatness Begins With Teachable, Forgiving Childlikeness

Matthew 18 begins:

At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus, saying, Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?

They were asking who denotes greatness and receives the most respect from heaven.

Jesus said:

Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.

The spiritual birth is like our natural birth. When we were born naturally, we came into the world knowing nothing, with a clean slate. When we are born again, we enter the kingdom the same way: as little children.

To humble yourself as a little child means to become completely teachable. The child Jesus used had the ability to be taught, to trust, and to forgive quickly. That is the attribute He connected with greatness.

When I came into the kingdom as a baby believer, I was willing to eat whatever anyone fed me. If someone said healing was not for everybody, I ate it. If someone said prosperity was not for everybody, I ate it. I was gullible, humble, and open.

Because baby Christians are open like that, the greater responsibility rests on the one teaching them.

Offending Little Ones Happens Through Strife and False Doctrine

Jesus said:

Whoso shall receive one such little child in my name receiveth me.

But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me...

To offend means to put a stumbling block in front of a little one that he may or may not recover from.

There are two main areas where stumbling blocks are placed. One is hatred, anger, strife, and unforgiveness. The other is false doctrine.

Jesus said it would be better for such a person to have a millstone hanged around his neck and be drowned in the sea. He then said:

Woe unto the world because of offences! for it must needs be that offences come; but woe to that man by whom the offence cometh!

He continues:

If thy hand or thy foot offend thee, cut them off...

If thine eye offend thee, pluck it out...

He is not telling us to mutilate the physical body. This body is the temple of God. He lives in me, walks in me, and has made His abode in me. We defile the body through destructive habits, and we defile the soul through hatred, unforgiveness, and strife. But Jesus is still talking about dealing with the flesh so seriously that anything in you that causes little ones to fall must be cut off at any cost.

I love my wife, my boys, my family, and the people around me too much to walk in unanswered prayer and strife. I refuse to live there any longer than it takes me to bring it into check and destroy it.

The Father Keeps Watch Over Every Little One

Jesus said:

Take heed that ye despise not one of these little ones; for I say unto you, That in heaven their angels do always behold the face of my Father which is in heaven.

In other words, angels are continually standing in God's presence on behalf of these little ones.

I remember being a new believer: gullible, teachable, willing to believe anything. I also remember how quickly God answered simple prayers.

I used to have pounding headaches that began at the back of my neck and crawled up over my head by the end of the day. I worked in a machine shop. After hearing a message on healing, I simply put my hand on the back of my head and prayed in the name of Jesus. Instead of getting worse, the headache immediately began to subside and disappeared.

Another time I was working on a railroad gang. I did not have a Bible I could carry, and the men around me were cussing while I was just trying to stay saved. I prayed a simple prayer: "God, it would sure help if I had a Bible." Suddenly an unction came on me to stand up and walk down the track. I walked a little way and found a small New Testament with the Gospel of John lying on the railroad track. I picked it up, went back, sat down, and began reading while the others cursed. By the next day I had memorized several verses.

That is how the Father treats little ones. That is why He warns us not to offend them.

The Straying Sheep Is the Trespassing Brother

Jesus continues:

For the Son of man is come to save that which was lost.
How think ye? if a man have an hundred sheep, and one of them be gone astray...

If one sheep goes astray, the shepherd leaves the ninety-nine and goes into the mountains to seek the one. If he finds it, he rejoices more over that sheep than over the ninety-nine that did not go astray.

What if one of these little ones is lost? What if one sheep goes astray? What are the steps of recovery?

That is why the next verse says:

Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee...

"Moreover" means Jesus is building on the foundation He has just laid. He is not changing subjects. He is talking about the straying sheep.

If your brother trespasses against you, who is the baby? The mature one, or the one doing the trespassing? Maturity in God's eyes is seen in the fruit of the Spirit: longsuffering, forgiveness, freedom from malice, anger, and strife. If someone comes to me with hatred and strife, I do not care how long he has been a Christian; God labels him a baby in that area because he is capable of those acts.

I was born again with my spirit seated in heavenly places with Christ Jesus, but my soul realm still had a boatload of problems. One of my worst habits was lying. It tried to manifest even later as exaggeration or misrepresenting truth. God cannot lie, and He cannot add Himself to your lies. To add Himself to a lie would destroy an attribute that makes Him God.

I also had anger and a short temper. Even as a baby Christian, I caused strife in other people's lives. So when we read Matthew 18 with ourselves on our minds, we miss the revelation. Jesus is not first giving us a method of self-vindication. He is showing us how to recover the little sheep who has gone astray.

The First Step Is Private Recovery, Not Public Vindication

Jesus says:

If thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone...

Suppose a baby Christian enters a business partnership with me and steals fifty thousand dollars. I discover the evidence and go to him alone. He admits it but refuses to repent, repay, or make anything right.

Most of the time we have the fifty thousand dollars on our minds. "How do I get my money back?" But God has the little sheep on His mind. Whether he used you as the victim of his trespass or not, he has still gone astray.

So we go to the rule book and take the next step.

Witnesses Establish the Condition for the Sake of the Church

Jesus says:

But if he will not hear thee, then take with thee one or two more, that in the mouth of two or three witnesses every word may be established.

So I bring two elders and ask them to hear the matter, weigh the words, and judge what is right. If the brother still refuses repentance or restitution, then every word has been established.

The next step is to tell it to the church, not so I can take revenge, but to protect the church and other business dealings from this man's condition.

Jesus says:

And if he shall neglect to hear them, tell it unto the church...

Then:

But if he neglect to hear the church, let him be unto thee as an heathen man and a publican.

At first I thought that meant, "Now I can treat him like the world. I can go after him and get my money at any cost." I remember meditating on this in Medford, Oregon, and thinking the lesson was settled. I got up and headed toward the door.

Then the Spirit of the Lord stopped me in the doorframe with these words: "You know better than that."

He reminded me that if a heathen slaps me on the cheek, Jesus said to turn the other. If he sues me for my coat, give him my cloak. If he spitefully uses me, pray for him. If he hates me, do good to him. How much more a little sheep who has gone astray?

I said, "But Lord, You said let him be unto me as a heathen and a publican."

He said, "Yes. Did you go to him personally? Did you go with two or three witnesses? Did you establish his condition with the church? He is determined to be a heathen and a publican to you. So let him be one to you. Do not be one to him. Since he is bent on being one anyway, turn him loose."

Binding and Loosing Releases Heaven to Recover the Brother

Now we come to the next step:

Verily I say unto you, Whatsoever ye shall bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever ye shall loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.

Again I say unto you, That if two of you shall agree on earth as touching any thing that they shall ask, it shall be done for them of my Father which is in heaven.

For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them.

Why is Jesus in the midst when two or three gather in His name for this kind of prayer? He is there to carry out the agreement.

We often take these verses out of context and preach them as general binding and loosing formulas. But in context, Jesus is still talking about the one sheep who went astray. The two or three are the witnesses who went with you, heard the matter, and weighed the case.

Now you gather those people and agree. Whatever the cross has bound in heaven through redemption, you have authority to bind on earth. Whatever the cross has loosed in heaven through redemption, you have authority to loose on earth.

In this situation, the Lord showed me what to do: bind the operation of the devil out of the brother's life, and loose him from his debt.

Binding is like taking a rope and tying something up. Loosing is like taking the rope off. So bind the opposing force that has the little believer tied up, and loose him from his debt so the Holy Ghost can track him down and recover him.

Strife Gives Evil Spirits Authority, but Forgiveness Releases Jesus

Witchcraft is not only occult rituals. It is also what happens when controlling spirits join with your hatred, strife, and anger. When you speak ugly things against someone, those spirits love to join the authority you are giving them in the earth to harass and destroy that person.

But if you refuse to open your mouth except for the recovery of that little sheep, and you bind the opposing force and loose him from his debt, you release Jesus Christ to go after him and recover him.

The last time people got into strife with me and did things against me, I took it further. I prayed for them in my motel room, then got up and wrote letters. I not only loosed them and forgave them; I wrote them a letter listing every good attribute I could think of in them. Then I put a love offering in the envelope to help establish them in their new church.

Why? Because I wanted their recovery.

Do not feel sorry for me for operating this way.

Peter's Question Reveals That the Whole Kingdom Operates by Forgiveness

Peter listened to Jesus teach about offenses, little ones, binding, loosing, and forgiveness. Finally he could not take it anymore:

Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times?

Jesus said:

I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.

In other words, Peter missed the thrust of the whole teaching. The whole kingdom operates on forgiveness and grace.

Jesus then told a parable of a servant who owed his lord an enormous debt. The servant had no way to pay it, and the lord commanded that he, his wife, and his children be sold. That is the debt we were enslaved under through the fall of Adam. We had no redemption price.

When the servant fell down and pleaded for patience, his lord was moved with compassion, loosed him, and forgave the debt.

Then that servant went out and found a fellow servant who owed him a small debt. He grabbed him by the throat, demanded payment, and threw him in prison when he could not pay.

The lord called him wicked. He had been forgiven a debt he could never pay, yet he imprisoned his brother over a tiny one.

Every Human Offense Is Small Beside the Debt We Were Forgiven

In God's eyes, everything anyone can do to you in this lifetime is a small debt compared with what you have been forgiven. If someone tied you up, beat you, used you, hated you, or threw you into prison, it would still be small beside the debt canceled for you in Christ.

Greatness in the kingdom belongs to the person who strives with God to forgive every brother and sister every debt incurred against him.

You had your debt canceled. You are born again. Do you have it in your heart to forgive the smaller debt?

The servant would not, so his lord turned him over to the tormentors. When you refuse forgiveness after receiving grace, you give the devil authority to torment that area of your life. You have violated grace.

The Spirit of Grace Teaches Us to Heal Those Imprisoned by the Evil One

The Spirit of God says that when you enter these realms of walking in His Spirit, many things will clear up to you and you will begin to see. The one who extracts the beam out of his own eye can see clearly to remove the mote from his brother's eye.

There are many areas where God desires to use you to bring healing to His people who have been put in prison by the evil one. Walk in His grace and goodness and teach them. He will move on your behalf when it seems impossible and there is no way to turn. He is the way to turn.

Yes, Father. Once again, thank You.

Trusting God's Vindication Frees Us From Lying, Fighting, and Fear

The only reason I would lie to bring a temporary resolution to a problem is because I do not have faith in the omnipotent God to bring a permanent solution.

Someone says, "If I just adjust my tax form a tiny bit, I will get three thousand dollars more. Nobody will know." But that person is believing the temporary blessing of three thousand dollars outweighs the blessing God would give for truth and purity of spirit.

It is the same with forgiveness. The only reason we refuse to forgive is because we do not believe the permanent solution God brings is greater than the situation we fight, claw, and hate over.

I am finding more and more that being exalted out of my problem does not necessarily mean getting out of jail. It means I have made a place of peace with my Father in whatever circumstance I find myself.

If I were thrown in jail over my testimony, getting out of jail would not necessarily be my first deliverance. First I want the peace of God. I have learned that in whatever state I am in, I can be content. If you sue me for ten million dollars, I will still sleep well, because the end of the matter is that I will be exalted.

You may get the money, but you will not take it from me. The moment you file papers against me, I will give it to you. You cannot take anything from me. I will turn the Holy Ghost loose on you, and if you think you will sue me and not get born again, you have another thought coming.

We are talking about the basics of prayer.

I smile because I have already been cut by the blade end of that sword. Do you want to grow, or do you want to sit in church for the next ten years and have no more ability to believe God then than you do now?

We are not going to be the same way ten years from now.

Stand up and worship.